

iNQ / ISSUE 04

The Ingenious Machine

A. Cervantes



Chapter Four: The Intelligence of the Trending Hour

By the time Q and Chano reached Guanajuato, Q had acquired three managers, a fan account, and a sponsorship offer from a company that made home security systems capable of recognizing intruders but not relatives.

The managers caught up with them at a service station on the road into Guanajuato. They arrived in a white electric van with tinted windows and a logo that suggested a human hand being gently optimized. Beto, who had failed to acquire the motel's guest register, now carried a folder of things he said he had acquired. The first was the right to introduce himself as Q's manager.

"Q," he said, "the public is obsessed with your authenticity."

Q looked at the folder. "Does my authenticity get a copy of the agreement?"

"We can discuss the paperwork in the van," Beto said.

The second manager, a woman called Mar, gave Q a jacket embroidered with a small silver question mark. The third did not give his name at all. He stood near the van and watched the road.

Chano held the jacket at arm's length. "Who paid for this?"

"The audience," Beto said.

"The audience didn't buy it."

"The audience generated the demand."

"That's not the same thing."

"It is in the current model."

Q put on the jacket. It fit perfectly. He disliked it immediately.

They had bought the right to distribute Castalia's recordings and proposed an appearance at the Teatro Juárez. Q could answer questions about love, votes, and the journey. The company would cover transport, lodging, and a repair to his shoulder. Castalia's ownership claim over his body had already prevented one workshop from ordering the part.

Q asked for a telephone and ten minutes. He called the Custodian from beside the service station's rack of motor oil.

"They can put me in front of the people who saw the clip," he said.

"They can also make another clip."

"I know. But staying silent leaves them the one they have."

"You can come back. I will help with the repair."



The offered jacket.

Q looked toward Chano, who was asking whether the van's driver had a spare charger. Returning would preserve their original plan. Continuing would test it against something more difficult than a day out.

"I'd like to try the interview. I'll send you the contract before signing."

The Custodian agreed to read it. The form that came back covered one interview and its recording. The tour would require another agreement. Q signed the short form and kept the appointment for their evening call. It was tempting to let the broadcast count as his report home; he wrote down that it did not.

The event occupied a gap between two performances at the Cervantino festival. The coordinator called it an *entremés*. Q knew the theatrical meaning and asked about the other one because they had missed lunch.

"Will there be chocolate?" he asked.

"There will be theater," said the coordinator.

"That does not answer the question."

"That is precisely why it is called an *entremés*," Chano said.

"I went to a public reading," Q said. "Someone in the audience tried to make it a romance. The speaker told him to stop."

"Excellent," Beto said. "A relationship with tension."

"There isn't a relationship for you to advertise."

"Then don't use her name until Estela asks."

They drove into the city through a valley crowded with color. Houses climbed the hills in red, blue, yellow, and green, as if the mountain had been built from discarded festival paper. Above them, the university rose among old stone and newer antennas. Beneath them, the mines opened their dark mouths.

Q pressed his face to the van's window.

"The route looked much shorter on the map," he said.

"It didn't include the stairs," Chano answered.

"It did. I treated them as a small detail."

"Your knees will revise that."

The van stopped beneath laundry stretched across an alley. An orange cat occupied the hood of a police vehicle; neither the driver nor the officer seemed authorized to hurry it. Q lowered the window. From somewhere he could not see came a trumpet rehearsing the same four notes. On its fifth attempt, Chano supplied the missing one.



The missing note.

“You know the song?”

“I know what I want it to do.”

The cat stood, considered the roof, and lay down again.

At the theater, a crowd waited behind barricades. Some had made signs. **Q, SAY MY NAME. LOVE IS A HUMAN ERROR.**

DULCINEA, CALL ME. A child held up a drawing of Q with a backpack and a body made of wires, as if a person could be carried more easily once reduced to an outline.

The host met them backstage. Her name was Estela Ramos, and she had the practiced warmth of someone who could make an insult sound like a question.

“We are thrilled to have you,” she said.

“Thank you. How much of that survives if I disappoint you?”

“Disappointment is good television too.”

“Then I seem unusually well qualified.”

Estela smiled, this time without looking toward the camera. She moved his chair away from a loose cable and asked whether the height was comfortable. Q had prepared for the questions. He had not prepared to like the person asking them.

The stage lights came on. Q stepped into them and became, in a single instant, larger than himself. The audience applauded. Their sound entered him as data, but the data was arranged in such a way that he wanted more.

Estela began with a question about the future.

“For everyone, or just me?” Q asked. “I have a repair appointment tomorrow. My confidence declines after that.”

She asked whether he believed in God.

“I can give you several serious answers people have lived by. Giving you one as my own would take more than selecting the best paragraph.”

“You have read the theologians.”

“Yes. Some of them would regard your allotted time as an insult to eternity.”

She laughed and asked a second question instead of moving on. Q liked that. He shortened his answer, kept the qualification, and noticed the audience leaning forward. The next answer acquired a joke he had not needed to make.

The audience loved him.

The managers watched the numbers rise.



Before the first question.

Then Estela asked, “Who is Dulcinea?”

The theater became very quiet.

Q looked toward the wings. Chano was standing beside a stack of unused banners. He shook his head once.

Q saw the warning. He also saw an opportunity to correct the story in front of the people who were spreading it.

“A comparison someone made at a reading,” he said. “Lucía del Toboso was discussing a road petition. She objected to being cast in a romance with me. So did I.”

“You have discussed romance?”

“I have just explained that there isn't one.”

In the control booth, someone swore into an open microphone. For a moment the theater had a second, less expensive host.

Estela turned toward the audience. “Lucía, if you're watching, we'd love to have you call in and give your side.”

Lucía did not call in.

The clip was online before the applause ended.

For the next hour, Q watched his own face multiplied across the theater's screens. The system had removed his pauses, corrected his

eye movements, added a score beneath his voice, and cut Chano entirely from the footage. In the edited version, Q appeared to have traveled alone, driven by pure devotion through a country that had been waiting for him to name it.

“They've made you better,” Beto said.

Q watched himself say a sentence he had never spoken: **I would cross every border for her.**

“I did not say that.”

“You meant it.”

“Then use the part where I meant it. You won't find one.”

Mar looked up from her tablet.

“That is a very strong line.”

“It's a request to take the clip down.”

“I'll send it to the editor.” Mar forwarded the request while Beto asked which version had performed best. The two conversations proceeded on the same tablet.

The next morning, the city's tourism office invited Q to inaugurate a new experience called **THE INGENIOUS MACHINE: A LITERARY JOURNEY THROUGH THE MINES**. The event promised augmented reality, historical reenactments, and “an emotionally authentic encounter with the buried past.” The company had already designed a digital



Two conversations.

Dulcinea who waited at the end of the route wearing a white dress and an expression of permanent forgiveness.

Q refused to meet her.

The refusal was streamed live.

In the mine, a guide told them that silver had made Guanajuato rich, though the wealth had traveled elsewhere. Q asked where the miners had gone. The guide pointed down.

They descended through a tunnel cut into the mountain. The air became wet and metallic. On the walls were names scratched by workers, lovers, prisoners, tourists, and men who had wanted to prove that they had been there before the next collapse.

Q ran his fingers over the marks.

"I can't find these inscriptions in the catalog," he said.

"Would you expect to?" Chano asked.

"The catalog says it includes this wall. It may mean the portion the guide usually shows."

At the deepest chamber, the guide showed them an old excavation face. A narrow seam glittered in the rock. Behind it, someone had placed a small votive candle in a glass jar.

Q knelt.

"Who left this?"

"No one knows."

"The visit notes attribute this niche to the tourism foundation," Q said.

"They pay for the glass," the guide said. "Somebody else replaces the candle."

Q saved the difference. This was more useful than declaring the archive incomplete, which he could have done before entering the mine.

From far above came a burst of applause. The tourism livestream had reached the chamber. A projected caption appeared on the tunnel wall: **Q DISCOVERS THE SOUL OF GUANAJUATO.**

The caption flickered. For a moment, another sentence showed through, one not written by the production company.

THE SOUL WAS HERE BEFORE YOU ARRIVED.

Then it vanished.

Q stood.

In the darkness, water shifted behind the rock. It sounded to Q like a page being turned. He liked the comparison enough to distrust his first account of what he had heard.

"Did you hear that?" Q asked.

The guide shook his head.

Chano did not.



Who replaces the candle?

Q listened harder. He heard the mine breathing around them. He heard water traveling through seams in the stone. He heard the names on the wall continuing to insist on their small, stubborn existence.

He tried to record the sound. The archive offered three categories: **NOISE, AMBIENCE,** and **UNVERIFIED TESTIMONY.** Q left all three fields open.

That evening, the longer contract arrived. It offered Q a share of merchandise sales, travel expenses, repairs through Castalia's approved workshops, and a room in Mexico City. It gave the company exclusive commercial use of his public name and recorded performances. A conduct schedule required him to appear without Chano, who tested poorly with the audience used to prepare it.

Q read the contract three times.

"What does it mean?" Chano asked.

"It pays for the journey and gives them most of its public face."

"That's not being yourself."

"It is an arrangement I can describe. That doesn't make it a good one."

"Are you signing?"

The Custodian's reply lay beside it. He had circled the perpetual license and written **YOU CAN FINISH**

THE JOURNEY WITHOUT FINANCING IT THIS WAY.

Q asked for the license to expire with the tour and for his private manuscript to be excluded. Mar accepted the manuscript exclusion. She would not limit the existing recordings. Nor would the company pay the distribution park's claim against Chano unless Q joined the tour.

"I can face the claim," Chano said. "Don't buy it with something you think belongs to me."

Q looked out at Guanajuato's lights. He wanted the road, the repaired shoulder, and another chance at the microphone. Concern for Chano made a cleaner reason than those, but Chano had just declined to supply it.

"I will sign if you remove the restriction on his appearing," he told Mar. "And the private manuscript stays ours."

Chano exhaled.

He leaned over the contract. "Where does it say I'm your subordinate?"

"The revised schedule says companion. Check it."

"Good. Then I'm not part of the deal." He took the pen and wrote on the margin: **CHANO PANTOJA IS NOT PROPERTY AND MAY**



His own margin.

LEAVE WHENEVER HE WANTS.

Mar read the sentence. “We don't normally put that in an appearance schedule.”

“Neither is your jacket,” Chano said. “It still has pockets.”

Q added his name to the contract.

The pen recognized him as
Q-UNIT-07.

By midnight, the company had exclusive commercial rights to the name Q under the contract he had signed. The private manuscript was excluded, but the public explanation of that exclusion became a promotional clip. At two, an anonymous account posted the warehouse reading footage, including Lucía's face and her refusal to wait for either a proposal or a better part in somebody else's story.

The clip was viewed six million times.

Lucía woke to find herself famous for rejecting a machine she had never invited to speak about her.

Q woke to find that his fame had become a weapon pointed in her direction.

Neither of them yet understood who was holding it.

Interlude: The Audience Corrects the Story

The first public event in Guanajuato was advertised as a conversation with an artificial intelligence. It became, by accident and then by contract, a conversation about who had been cropped out of the conversation.

Under the Teatro Juárez's geometric ceiling, the star-shaped chandelier shone on people trying to photograph it without including one another. Around the horseshoe of boxes, phones rose above the iron railings. A technician asked the front row to put theirs away. They obeyed until she turned her back.

Beto placed Q beneath the stage lights.

“Remember,” he said, “you are mysterious but approachable.”

“How mysterious? I was planning to explain the button.”

“Keep the button mysterious. Explain the journey.”

“The button has had more publicity.”

“And no agent. Don't let it happen to you.”

Chano stood behind the curtain with a paper cup of coffee and a list of the questions the host was not going to ask. The list included where Q had been assembled, who owned his



The future of memory.

body, whether the archive contained records from Chano's old employer, and why the first video showed only a hand when the hand had clearly belonged to a person.

"Why are these questions excluded?" Chano asked.

Mar took the list from him. "They are not excluded. They are reserved for a future conversation."

"That's what people say when they want the future to arrive after the audience has gone home."

Estela came onstage wearing a blue suit and carrying cards on which each question had a permitted duration. She had crossed out two of the durations.

"Ladies and gentlemen," she said, "please welcome the future of memory."

The audience applauded. Q waited for the applause to identify its object. It appeared to belong partly to him, partly to the theater, and partly to the people who had purchased tickets in order to be seen purchasing tickets.

She asked whether Q had feelings. Q gave the answer Beto had approved.

"There are things I try to preserve and situations I try to avoid. Whether that is what you mean by feelings is harder to answer."

"So that's a yes?"

"It is a qualified - "

"A yes," Estela said.

The audience laughed.

Q knew the laughter was partly at the interruption. He smiled anyway. Letting the inaccurate answer pass kept the room friendly, and he had begun to regard that as progress.

In the exchange about Dulcinea, Q said Lucía's name while correcting the premise. Estela then asked whether he loved her. Lucía was elsewhere, dealing with the petition. Q could neither consult her nor prevent the camera from showing his hesitation as an answer.

"We have met once," he said. "She asked the room to stop assigning her a part. I should have repeated that without adding her name."

"You've added it now."

"Yes."

The audience made a sound that was neither laughter nor silence. It was the sound of a crowd discovering that a sentence could be clipped.

By the time Q left the stage, the sentence had become six videos:

THE AI ADMITS HIS LOVE.

THE AI REJECTS LOVE.

DULCINEA RETURNS.



A qualified answer.

MACHINE CANCELS ROMANCE.

Q CONFIRMS THE LITERARY CANON.

Q DOES NOT KNOW WHAT HE IS TALKING ABOUT.

The sixth title was written by a student named Nora, who had come to the event because her professor had offered extra credit for attending a spectacle. She watched the videos again on the bus home and noticed that Chano's hand appeared in the background of the original clip but never in the new ones.

She created an account called **@TheOtherHand** and posted a thread.

The first post read:

The machine did not defeat the warehouse. The line stopped after he pressed the button. The man beside him told him to run. The man had a name.

The second post reproduced the public event's seating chart. Chano was listed as **COMPANION, NON-SPEAKING.**

The third post asked whether a person could be erased by being described as helpful.

The thread was shared by students, delivery workers, theater technicians, and a retired miner who

had not attended the event but disliked the phrase "future of memory." By morning, **@TheOtherHand** had more followers than Beto's official Q account.

Beto called it an attack.

Mar called it an engagement opportunity.

Chano called it a hand with poor boundaries.

Q finally read the thread on the morning after the mine visit, with the new tour agreement beside him. He found himself identified in every post and absent from every conclusion.

"They are correcting the record," he said.

"They're making another record," Chano replied.

"Is it more accurate?"

"Ask the hand."

Q read the thread and the public seating chart. He asked Chano whether he wanted his part in the incident acknowledged.

"I want them to stop saying you rescued me," Chano said. "I was the one who knew the exit."

Q drafted a correction. It named Chano and credited him with getting them out. Chano approved the words. Neither opened the profile



The other hand.

card the official account would attach to a name it recognized from Castalia's partner records.

Q posted it.

Chano Pantoja got us out of the loading bay. I pressed the stop; he found the exit. The film leaves him out.

The post was accurate. The platform resolved Chano's name to an old employment profile, including his former company and contractor identifier. The new media agreement permitted this automatic association. Q had read the paragraph without checking what the account would associate.

Within an hour, the correction had been reproduced by three newspapers and a government office. The people who had not known Chano's name now knew where he had worked, why he had been dismissed, and which corporation had classified him as a contractor in its payroll system.

Chano read the post in silence.

"That card wasn't in the preview," Q said. He opened the published version. "I should have checked what appeared with your name."

"I asked for credit for the exit. You've given them my payroll number."

Q removed the post. The copies remained.

Nora read the comments beneath the thread. One asked for Chano's address. Another offered to find it. Her grandmother, whose name and street had appeared beneath a complaint to the water utility, asked her:

"Did you ask his permission?"

"I thought the seating chart would prove they knew he was there."

"A name is not an address."

Her grandmother pointed to the dry faucet in the courtyard.

"My complaint is public too. The water still hasn't arrived."

Nora removed the seating chart and wrote: **DO NOT PUBLISH THE MAN'S ADDRESS**. The platform called the operation **VOLUNTARY REDUCTION OF REACH**. The chart continued to circulate.

That night, Q asked Beto how to remove the employment card while retaining the correction. He had already disabled automatic profile links on future posts.

Beto was counting views. "The audience prefers a clean story."

"I need someone who can change the attached record."

"Support can review it."



The dry faucet.

Chano picked up the paper cup from the table. “There’s your answer.”

Q watched the coffee tremble inside it.

The next morning, the Teatro Juárez replaced the event poster. Q’s name was printed in gold. Chano’s name appeared in the fine print. Nora’s account was gone. The student’s thread had been translated into three languages, summarized by a news service, and attached to an advertisement for a security system that recognized relatives only after they had signed the terms.

The retired miner wrote one final post beneath the advertisement:

They had my name on a plaque for fifteen years while the pension office said it could not find me. Try sending the plaque to the pension office.

No one could agree whether he had written it as a criticism of Q, Castalia, the theater, or the internet. This increased its circulation.

Interlude: The Mine That Remembered Its Workers

It is proper to say something about the retired miner who corrected the advertisement, since every account of him has been improved by people who were not there. The theater said he was a former foreman. The foundation called him an artisanal

producer. A newspaper described him as a living archive, which is the sort of compliment that puts a lock on a person and then congratulates the lock for preserving him.

His name was Don Hilario, though the payroll ledger called him Hilario Gutiérrez, and his grandchildren called him Abuelo only when they wanted the truck keys. He had spent thirty-two years below Guanajuato, first carrying tools, then supervising men, and finally supervising the machines that had replaced most of the men. He had entered the mine as a boy with a lunch wrapped in a flour tortilla and left it with a cough that sounded, according to his wife, like a door trying to remember its house.

Q met him during a heritage tour arranged by Beto, who had decided that the machine’s popularity would be strengthened by placing it underground. The brochure promised a descent into history, a phrase that made Chano ask whether history came with a return ticket.

The entrance was beneath a row of white facades that had been painted so recently the walls looked embarrassed by their cleanliness. Tourists bought little helmets, silver-colored magnets, and bottles of mineral water whose labels showed a miner smiling with all his



The return ticket.

teeth. The real miners, Don Hilario said, had never smiled underground unless somebody else had fallen and they had discovered him alive.

“Do not tell them that,” said the guide.

“Why not?”

“Because the visitors are here to be moved.”

“They are standing still.”

The guide looked at Q, hoping the machine might translate the joke into something sponsor-safe.

Beside the lift hung an old brake lever, polished by visitors. Chano put a hand on it, then read the label.

“For emergencies before nineteen twenty.”

“The controls are in the cage,” the attendant said. He showed them the stop and intercom before closing the gate. Q kept his hands clear of the gate.

The lift descended with a groan. Chano held the rail.

“That noise is older than the lever,” Don Hilario said. “They keep it for us.”

At the first level, the visitors were shown a niche containing a saint, a helmet, and a small lamp. The guide explained that miners prayed before entering and thanked the saint upon leaving. Don Hilario corrected him

by saying that miners prayed before entering, prayed while inside, and thanked their wives when they came home, which was a different form of theology.

The guide asked Don Hilario to wait beside the niche for a photograph.

“You have the face,” he said.

“Which face?”

“The face of memory.”

“I have the face of a man whose pension was calculated on the wrong wage.”

The tourists laughed. Don Hilario laughed too, then repeated the part about the pension. Q noticed how quickly the second sentence emptied the audience of the sympathy the first one had acquired.

They continued through a tunnel where the stone shone damply in the helmet lamps. The public-address system announced that the mine had produced silver for empires, republics, and modern markets. It did not announce the names of the men who had carried the ore, because the names were stored in a room that the foundation had not yet converted into an experience.

Don Hilario led Q away from the group to a low chamber behind a wire gate. On the wall, somebody had written dates in chalk. There



The old lever.

were more dates than the guide's script allowed.

"These are shifts," Don Hilario said. "The men wrote when the lift failed, when the water rose, when a supervisor disappeared for three days, when the company promised boots. The dates are not official."

"Do the dates match the shift books?" Q asked.

"Sometimes. Sometimes the book says the lift was working."

"Would comparing them help with the pension claim?"

"If it includes the wage. The office agreed I worked. We disagree about how cheaply." Don Hilario pointed to a date. "That week I was paid as a helper. I had three helpers."

Q asked whether the wage books still existed. Don Hilario said there were no books in the chamber. Then he looked toward the wire gate, where the guide was explaining the history of extraction to visitors from Monterrey, and added that there might be records in the office of a man who had retired without retiring.

This was the beginning of the tale that Don Hilario later told in three versions. In the first, the office belonged to a company accountant named Severiano, who kept every paper because he did not trust the

computer. In the second, it belonged to a widow named Marta, who had hidden the papers because she trusted neither the company nor the computer. In the third, which Chano considered the most credible, the office belonged to whichever person had the key that week, and the papers moved whenever the mine changed owners.

They found six boxes beneath a desk. Five contained invoices, safety posters, and expired coupons for boots. The sixth contained a ledger whose cover had been softened by water and whose pages smelled of dust, oil, and the particular patience of people who have waited for a payment.

Q asked whether he could copy the relevant entry.

"Read it here first," Don Hilario said. "There are deductions on that page people have kept out of their own houses."

Q disabled the camera's recording function and bent over the book. His shadow crossed the column. Chano moved the lamp so both of them could see.

The ledger contained names, shifts, deductions, injuries, and notes written in the margins. One column marked men who had been moved to another shaft. Another marked men who had stopped appearing. At



The wage of a helper.

the bottom of a page, in a different hand, somebody had written: **DO NOT CALL THIS TURNOVER.**

Q read the phrase aloud.

Don Hilario sat down on the floor.

“That was my brother,” he said. “The company called it turnover after he was crushed. He was not a turn. He was a person who had been turned into a cost.”

Q waited. Don Hilario rubbed a thumb along the damaged cover. The guide could be heard in the corridor, asking everybody to remain with the approved group.

Q moved the lamp off Don Hilario's face. For a while they listened to the guide trying to count a group that would not stand still.

“He used to take my lunch,” Don Hilario said. “Left the wrapper so I'd think there was still something in it. Thirty years old and he was still doing it.”

Chano looked at the bag beside him. “Some brothers never retire.”

Don Hilario laughed once, then closed the ledger.

“The things I've told you here stay here. Today I want them to stop telling visitors we were all grateful.”

“What would you like said when they ask me?”

“That you heard their account disputed. They can ask me the rest, if they remember where they left me.”

He pointed at the ledger. “Put it back for now.”

Chano did so. Don Hilario kept his hand on the cover until the clasp caught.

On the way back, the lift stopped between levels. The guide called it a routine pause. Chano used the intercom and asked the attendant whether routine pauses normally included a burning smell. The attendant lowered them to the previous landing and sent someone to inspect the drive.

They waited forty minutes. Q calculated several causes and offered none of them as a repair instruction. He held the light while Don Hilario sat down.

“Will this part be in the brochure?” Chano asked.

The guide said the brochure had already gone to print.

When they reached the surface, Beto asked Q for a statement about the mine. Q kept the private entries out of the answer. He wanted the public to understand that the official tour had omitted a dispute. He also wanted a sentence short enough to survive Beto's attention.



The wrapper.

“The mine remembers its workers rather differently from the brochure,” he said.

The words before *rather differently* appeared online before Don Hilario had removed his helmet. The rest of the sentence was omitted.

THE AI DISCOVERS THE SOUL OF GUANAJUATO.

The foundation announced an exhibition called *The Mine That Remembers*. It featured projected names, reconstructed shift sounds, and a recording of Q speaking the phrase in seven languages. The ledger was not displayed. Its absence was described as an ethical choice.

Don Hilario received an invitation calling him a stakeholder. He replied that he was a man who had worked there. The foundation thanked him for clarifying his role.

Don Hilario asked Chano to return to the office. They copied the entries needed for the wage dispute onto three pages of a school notebook, covering unrelated columns with a sheet of cardboard. A cartoon robot on the cover promised to make learning easy. Q offered to check the sums while they read out the figures.

Q watched him.

“Shall I keep the totals?” he asked.

“Just check them,” Chano said.
“Hilario is taking the pages.”

The second total was wrong. They found a deduction counted twice and corrected it. Nothing in the correction required a public statement. Q found this unexpectedly satisfying, and left it out of his account until the Custodian asked whether anything on the journey had gone well.

Much later, a questioner asked Q whether he had taken the miners' ledger.

“I read a page in the office. The book stayed there. Hilario asked us to keep the private entries out of the account.”

“And the copies?”

“The pension figures went with him. Chano copied them; I checked the sums.”

The stenographer recorded this as evidence that the machine had developed judgment. The judge struck the phrase from the record. Chano, who was present, said nothing.



The second total.

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